THOMAS ROBOTHAM



CINEMATIC STORYTELLING

A COMPREHENSIVE GUIDE FOR DIRECTORS AND CINEMATOGRAPHERS



A **Focal Press** Book

ROUTLEDGE

Cinematic Storytelling

This book presents a new, story-based approach to cinematic coverage and storytelling in film and video. It breaks from the conventional idea that shots are the fundamental unit of filmmaking, instead exploring the specifics of determining coverage. Keyframes in patterns are introduced, delivering scripted material in a context-rich presentation that supports the storytelling.

All the analysis, interpretation, and creative decision making is done first, with shots derived as the very last step. Scripted material is divided into six categories with associated patterns. Like cinematic building blocks, these can freely stack up and interconnect, supporting creativity and avoiding rigid formulas. This approach enables filmmakers to tap into the film "language" that audiences already understand and put it to practical use, helping the audience to feel the storytelling deeply. Dozens of film examples are provided throughout, plus conceptual and camera diagrams to contextualize the methods presented, and exercises are provided to reinforce concepts. Emphasis is placed on supporting performance and story meaning through a cinematic context. With all the concepts and decision-making options described and shown in examples, a scripted scene is analyzed and developed through an eight-step process, illustrated with storyboard, camera diagrams, and ultimately shot list descriptions.

The book is ideal for filmmaking students interested in directing and cinematography, as well as aspiring and early-career filmmakers, cinematographers, and directors.

Thomas Robotham teaches screenwriting, filmmaking, and cinematography. He is currently Affiliated Faculty at Emerson College, and Director of Photography (DP) in the International Cinematographers Guild. He holds a patent in light-emitting diode (LED) lighting for film and video. Thomas has also worked as Creative Director (advertising) and as a fine artist (sculpture). www.robotham.com


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This book is dedicated to all my students – past, present, and future.


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Preface

There are many books and resources for directors ***or*** cinematographers. But very little is written about what they work on together – the central area where they overlap and collaborate. That is in the planning of coverage – the choices of imagery to present the entire story.

Directors are responsible for the storytelling in all its manifestations. Cinematographers are responsible for the pictures, in both aesthetic and technical dimensions. Coverage falls into an overlapping zone of responsibilities – cinematic storytelling. That is the sole focus of this book.

This book presents a new, story-based approach to cinematic storytelling in film and video. We focus on how the audience feels and grasps the storytelling through the film "language" they already know. We link that to the mechanisms that will produce the physical and emotional responses that the filmmakers want the audience to feel. Dozens of examples are presented, along with conceptual and camera diagrams.

The book is intended to give filmmakers a shared framework for understanding coverage in storytelling terms. The concepts apply to stories of any length, from short films to feature films to long-form, multi-episode stories.

I've taught filmmaking to undergraduates and adult career-changers. What I have found is that – regardless of age or experience – deciding what to shoot is the hardest part. It can be an amorphous and confounding challenge without some framework for thinking about it clearly and creatively. That's what I hope to provide.

This is not just an issue for students. Except at the level of expert filmmakers, it can actually be quite hit-or-miss. Ideally, the story and the imagery create a whole that is bigger than the sum of its parts. How many shows – regardless of their budget – reach that high bar? Many productions fall short. That's a shame, because great ideas and deep feeling get lost before they reach the audience. Tremendous amounts of work go unrewarded when the cinematic storytelling falls short.

Other filmmaking professionals, beyond directors and cinematographers, have a stake in the cinematic storytelling. Producers have the ultimate interest in making the most of the script and in how their filmmaking team works together. Having a language for ephemeral and abstract concepts can

help make creative discussions productive. Editors need to understand the components of cinematic storytelling to open up creative opportunities in the editorial shaping of coverage. Actors may want insights on how camera usage can be supportive of performance.

This book is written for anyone who wants to be a filmmaker or wants to understand some of the things that filmmakers do at a fundamental level, to orient and inform the audience and shape their experience at a subconscious level.

One more thing: None of this book is "the Truth" with a capital T. These ideas do not replace the art and craft of filmmaking with something shiny and new. This book is just a way to talk about a complex creative task, breaking it down into ideas and processes. It is describing and systematizing what many film professionals already know at a gut level. The way you use a camera affects how the audience engages with, responds to, and feels the storytelling.

I hope you find this book useful in your quest to make movies that entertain us, make us think, and above all, make us feel deeply.

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Chapter 1
What is cinematic storytelling?

The pictures help us feel the story

Cinematic storytelling means putting the moving pictures to use, helping the audience feel the story. This means trusting the imagery to carry story weight. Fundamentally, it means the camera is serving the story.

The moving images are not simply there to record performances but also to present them to the audience in a way that clarifies and deepens their meaning. The pictures do not exist on their own, like a flashy sideshow or visual decoration. The pictures present story information and the movie conventions help us understand it. Their job is to help communicate the story and to help us, the audience, feel the unique and special nature of the story.

The cinematic storytelling for every movie is unique in its own way. It's not like baking a cake, where one recipe works each and every time. Effective cinematic storytelling is never the same thing twice. A cinematic approach could be very plain for a quiet, character-based story. It might be very flashy in support of a stylized thriller. We will need to dig deep below the surface in order to find the commonalities that unite all of the different ways that cinematic storytelling works to support the story and helps the audience to really feel its impact.

This book is about making thoughtful, story-centered creative choices to suit the material at hand. The goal is to help you think about and make choices that are firmly anchored in the scripted storytelling. If the choices are formulaic, they will come across as mechanical. If the decision making is isolated from story needs, the results will be arbitrary and lack emotional depth. If copied from other movies, it will feel derivative and lack its own emotional fingerprint. These are pitfalls that a story-centered approach can help filmmakers avoid.

Each motion picture can and should be unique to the scripted storytelling, deeply felt and thoughtfully presented. With a creative process that is story-centered, you can make highly individual choices that will feel coherent, cohesive, and emotionally resonant with the storytelling.

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A cinematic approach through keyframes – not shots

The general standard for going from script to screen is to start with making a shot list. That is almost the last thing we will do, discussed in the final chapters. The shot is not the fundamental unit of this approach. It is the end product.

The fundamental unit for us is the frame. We will take a ***keyframe*** approach in laying out a detailed and deep analysis of how moving pictures serve the storytelling. A keyframe is a representative frame, and its qualities connect the script to the images. Patterns of keyframes deliver the movie conventions that the audience understands, without conscious thought, in their assembly of the story and its possible meanings.

We will investigate keyframes and patterns, their connection to audience comprehension, and their foundational connections to the script. With these ideas in hand, your creative process will be rooted in the script, "growing" imagery that fully supports your individual story.

Cinematic storytelling exists for every form, length, and budget

Although the examples in this book are almost exclusively from feature films, I see little difference between feature films, short films, or multi-episode long-form series in terms of the cinematic storytelling. All have similar problems and opportunities at the level of cinematic choice. Everything in this book should be applicable to all forms and lengths of narrative storytelling using motion picture cameras of any type or cost.

Great movies exist at every length and every budget. Most aren't perfect or flawless. They don't have to be. They do have to be compelling, engaging, and satisfying. A confident hand at cinematic storytelling will bring you a long way toward those goals.

Not every filmmaker needs to be a genius. By tightly integrating the visual presentation with the script, we can make sure that the story and characters found in the script will feel vivid on the screen. That's cinematic storytelling. It takes effort and creative courage, not genius, so it is within the grasp of most of us who love movies enough to want to make them.

Going beyond formulas or easy solutions

You can find lots of explanations of famous shots in famous movies. We may want to "borrow" those, hoping they will have the same beneficial result in our own work. That ignores the facts – different script, different creative contributors, different budgets, etc. Borrowing shots is like borrowing precisely tailored clothes. Or like taking the wheel off someone's car and trying to install it on a different make and model. They won't fit. You can utilize underlying concepts and approaches. They will, by necessity, result in different shots. That is good. They will custom-fit your movie, not someone else's.

It is easy to be distracted by technical tools, thinking they might provide answers. Cameras and lenses are a lot of fun. Add all the specialized mounts and gizmos, and you could spend forever thinking about them and not the storytelling. But if you postpone the fun of playing with high-quality toys,

you can solidify the purpose behind making the images. Then, all these wonderful devices stop being toys and instead become creative tools for the execution of story-based decisions.

Throughout this book, we will look at many examples – not to find a cookbook formula but to find the underlying factors that make the presentation story-centered. We can find common approaches in a vast range of movies, indicating that coming up with unique cinematic storytelling isn't "secret knowledge," just something that needs study and practice. These fundamentals exist across the vast range of films, but you need to train yourself to see them.

Consider this – we don't need to invent new letters to express ourselves with different words. We don't need to invent words to communicate new or complicated ideas; we just choose the right words to convey meaning. We don't need to invent new notes to make a new melody. We take the underlying fundamentals and reapply them in new ways and new configurations to arrive at unique results.

Let's start with a few examples from actual movies, to point out some of the ways that the visual presentation contributes to the audience's visceral understanding of the story. We'll see how cinematic choices help us feel the progression of the story and enrich our understanding of character actions and relationships.

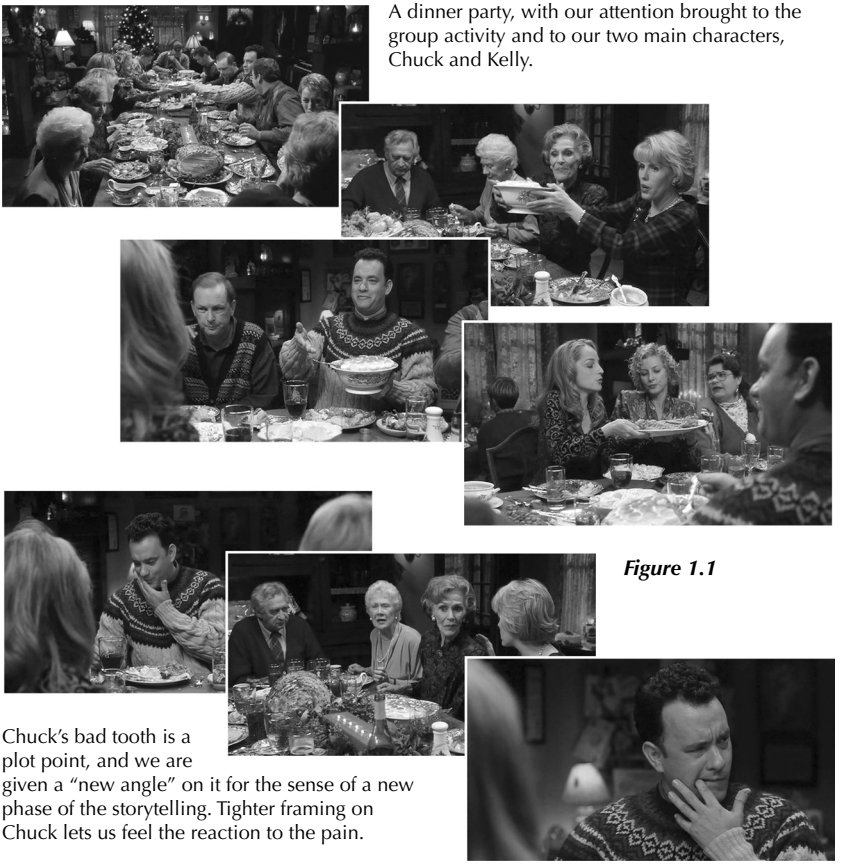
Clear presentation that informs and orients

Cinematic storytelling helps the audience respond to the storytelling and feel its emotional significance. The audience doesn't need to know how that works, but filmmakers do.

Our first example shows how the focus of the storytelling is clearly indicated through the progression of framings. In the movie *Cast Away*[1] (Figure 1.1, Figure 1.2), a family holiday dinner includes several plot points. This scene delivers the story event that sends our protagonist, Chuck, on his fateful journey. How do the framings and their progressions shape our understanding?

The scene starts with a wide frame of a holiday dinner. This introduces us to the main table and orients us to the activity – the big family dinner. Old folks sit at one end of the table, younger folks at the other, with main characters Chuck and Kelly in the middle. At first, we see groups, emphasizing the social nature of the situation. The first significant story point is when Chuck is asked about marriage plans. Chuck and Kelly have had a bet about that. Their brief dialogue has Chuck framed over the shoulder (OTS in shot terminology) of Kelly, and Kelly is shown OTS Chuck, keeping each in the other's frame of reference. (A list of some standard shot abbreviations is at the end of this chapter's Summary.)

Two things have happened. One is that by reducing the number of subjects in frame, we (the audience) understand that the center of the storytelling is now between them, not the larger group. The second is that, with the pattern of reciprocal, mirror-image framing, we know that Chuck and Kelly



A dinner party, with our attention brought to the group activity and to our two main characters, Chuck and Kelly.

Chuck's bad tooth is a plot point, and we are given a "new angle" on it for the sense of a new phase of the storytelling. Tighter framing on Chuck lets us feel the reaction to the pain.

Figure 1.1

are talking to each other, sharing mutual attention. This might not seem like a big deal, but it is.

Movies are filled with interpersonal interactions and dialogue. The basic pattern of reciprocal shot pairs will occur many times in many movies. The variations in the way they occur will be a major force in helping the audience feel the emotional flow of these interactions.

The next plot point is Chuck's wince over the pain of a bad tooth. Two things make this stand out so that we give it proper notice. One is the different angle on the old folks, which signals us that the prior flow has been interrupted and the story has gone in a new direction. The second is the first close-up (CU) of Chuck checking the tooth, OTS Kelly. These two visual cues, of change in a pattern and of closer focus on Chuck's reaction, give us a context for registering story progress and significance.

Immediately after the focus on his tooth, Chuck's beeper alerts him to a demand from work. The frame shifts from Chuck's CU to the beeper in his

Figure 1.2



Chuck's work beeper catches his attention, then Kelly's. The tighter frame on Kelly now matches that on Chuck, letting us feel the importance of her reaction.



This non-verbal exchange feels like silent dialogue centered on their interaction, leaving out the family. We can feel that this hits Kelly harder, with the small push-in on her reaction.

hand, like a magnet drawn to the object with story significance. We instantly register Kelly's gaze toward the beeper, and how it intrudes on the happy scene. We don't have to think about it – we see the intensity of her look, and we see the beeper and know that was the focus of her attention. These are simple mechanics in terms of shots, but they are critical to following the story.

A small, almost unnoticeable push-in on Kelly shows us how this new situation impacts Kelly's emotional state. Her disappointment makes sense because this is her family. Her potential future husband just let work interrupt Christmas dinner. We get the feeling that he's done this kind of thing before. This push-in on Kelly is intercut with Chuck and Kelly's pair of CU framings. Even though no words are spoken in the moment, we instantly recognize the silent conversation between them through the

pattern we associate with dialogue. Interpersonal interaction does not need spoken words – the pattern of shots tells us that they are communicating non-verbally.

The entire movie hinges on our understanding of the very simple chain of events. The emotional consequences of Chuck's actions, which feel like a minor disappointment in the moment, become life-changing for both characters.

Notice how the framing encompasses the entire social situation at the start, then the subset of social groups engaged with our main characters, and then the mutual connection between them as a couple. This progression tells us something fundamental: **What is in the picture has story significance, and what is out of the picture no longer does.** We know this, subconsciously, as movie-watchers. Now we need to make it part of our conscious focus as movie-makers.

The framing provides clear presentation of the story movement within the scene, from a broader social situation to the specific actions and reactions of our main characters. This gives us a clear chain of cause and effect (C&E as our abbreviation), from the toothache to the work interruption.

A big part of our understanding of movies comes from understanding people and social situations, and so we need to become consciously aware of how we do that, through what we see and hear. The clear focus on facial expressions lets us connect with the character's inner state – thoughts, feelings, and intentions. We can tell that the main characters are sharing these inner states and feelings through their mutual attention. The cinematic storytelling capitalizes on our ability to know and understand people and their behaviors.

We learn so much about their relationship from the way the scene is presented. That helps us share the feelings of Chuck being put on the spot. We can relate to Kelly, whose relationship is made fair game over dinner. Two very clear demonstrations of Chuck's current life trajectory are brought to our attention. He postpones important life actions (fixing his tooth) for the sake of his work. He will put everything with emotional significance, this dinner and the love of his life, on the back burner in favor of work. The clarity of the dinner scene sets up all of this.

The way the dinner is presented is conventional but highly effective. Much of what is considered "conventional" coverage can be understood in the story progression from the general to particular, wider to tighter. We go from the broader situation to the specific reactions of the main characters. We will see these concepts flexibly employed in a wide range of ways to suit the specifics of different stories and filmmakers.

We will also see examples of storytelling that don't fit the conventional mold but are comprehensible just the same because our attention is shaped, and our understanding is informed, by the cinematic storytelling.

Including us in a character's subjective attention

The next example showcases the basic filmmaking conventions that let us know what captures a character's attention, propelling their subjective experience into the center of story significance. In the movie *Midsommar*[2] (Figure 1.3), the main character is introduced through her strong emotional reaction to a disturbing email from her sister.

Dani is seen from the front, slightly above her eyeline, in keeping with seeing over the top of her laptop computer. She is upset and intent on her screen. We get closer to her as we get progressively closer framings of an email list, the specific message, and then the word "goodbye" that so alarms her.

The first shot of the laptop is easy to understand as her point of view (POV). The close-up (CU) and extreme close-up (ECU) of the screen are representing the focus of her attention – not necessarily all that she sees, but all that occupies her attention.

Movies allow us to enter into and share the subjective experiences of a character. It is done through their focused gaze, followed by the presentation of the subject of their attention. I refer to this as the ***Look/See*** pattern, because it is understood by the audience not as an isolated shot or frame but as a relationship between a character's subjective experience and our sharing of their attention and interest.

The Look/See pattern is the simplest of all clear and obvious patterns in filmmaking. It lets us comprehend story significance in terms of a character's inner motivations. Motion picture stories are usually centered on character experience. This pattern lets us enter and share that subjective experience, not just observe from the sidelines. This is at the root of the dialogue pattern we've seen in the prior example, known conventionally as ***shot-and-reverse***. The shot-and-reverse pattern is actually reciprocal Look/See patterns, indicating shared, mutual attention and interaction between two subjects. In the baseline Look/See pattern, the subject of the character's attention does not look back.

The more distant framing of Dani at her desk cools down the intensity and gives us some space to observe how she reacts. The next few frames show a clear chain of cause and effect (C&E), with her picking up her phone, scrolling to a choice, thinking twice, then committing and dialing Christian, whose name we see in close-up (CU).

We enter the next phase of the scene with her pivoting in her chair, giving us a new framing. For an instant she adjusts her hair and demeanor, clarifying that this is a boyfriend. Then she asks for support but is met with distance and judgment. We see this situation impinging on her with the camera pushing into a tighter CU.

This scene is all about the inner state of the character, Dani. Her subjective attention – her focused gaze – directs us to material with story



Figure 1.3

We connect with Dani's response to a disturbing email. From her look, we see the laptop. Then the intensity ramps up. We get closer to her and the word that is so upsetting.

We observe her reactions and reaching for the phone. She thinks twice, then makes the call. The CU on the phone tells us the call is to Christian. She pivots, facing a new direction for this new phase. We get closer to her as the intensity and intimacy increase and her inner state becomes the focus of the storytelling.

significance. The ramping up, down, and up again of the emotional intensity is tracked by how close we are – filled with her emotions – or through a cooling distance that gives us a chance to observe and assess her reactions in light of what little we already know or anticipate. Her misgivings about the phone call are proven true and give us the initial insight into her relationship with Christian – which is central to the entire movie.

Shifting perspective and physicality

Movies can make us feel things physically, not just emotionally. Consider how images of a roller coaster ride give us strong sensations in our bodies, as if we were there. This sensation is called kinesthesia. Films are uniquely able to convey physical sensations as part of the storytelling. Movies that deliver powerful physical feelings are among the most successful at drawing large audiences – even when characterization or plot development is weak. In the service of strong characters and a good story, kinesthesia can be wonderfully evocative, conveying subjective experiences and the resulting emotions.

In the movie *Gravity*[3] (Figure 1.4), novice astronaut Ryan Stone is repairing a circuit board on a satellite when a catastrophic hail of debris blows apart the space shuttle. Strapped to a remote arm, she is sent spinning off into space. We feel the panic-inducing spin and tumble of her body in our own bodies as we watch.

It is as if the character functions as our avatar in the movie-world, transmitting their physical sensations to us in our chairs. That observational, informational, full-body framing of the character allows us to see and feel their bodily sensations vicariously. This is also true for watching sports or dance performance. We can feel in our own bodies the motions and actions of the participants on screen.

The next phase begins with the camera drawn to Stone's tether – it must be disconnected before she is lost in space or burns up in the atmosphere. This gives us a clear example of action-scene C&E. The tether will kill her; she must conquer panic and follow orders, no matter how terrifying it is to be shot into the void. We feel this sense of being cut off through observing her rapid tumble into the distance, until she is just a tiny dot in the vastness.

We go into a third phase, aligned with her subjective experience, watching the earth, sun, and stars spinning around her. After that sense of shared subjective experience, we can easily relate to her fear and the sense of barely keeping emotions in check.

We get closer to her until we are visibly inside her helmet, looking out. When the framing goes to the earth spinning past her, we have entered into sharing the character's POV through a Look/See pattern in a continuous shot. We see her wide-eyed gaze and then see the earth spinning past, attaching us to her subjective experience in a powerful way. We have gone

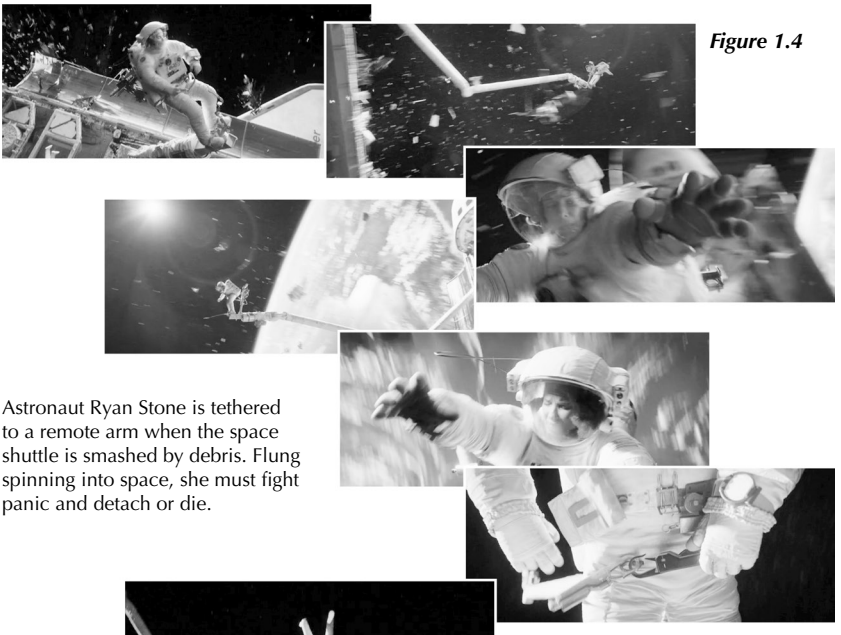


Figure 1.4

Astronaut Ryan Stone is tethered to a remote arm when the space shuttle is smashed by debris. Flung spinning into space, she must fight panic and detach or die.



We feel her end-over-end tumble. The perspective starts from outside her violent motion. We observe and feel the full-body spin. It shifts to her perspective, with the world spinning around her. We go inside her helmet and share her emotions and POV. We shift from objective physical to subjective emotional experience.

from observing through full-body framing, to connecting with her emotions through access to her expression, to seeing what she sees, putting us fully inside her subjective experience.

With so many levels of one character's experience presented to us, we have no trouble understanding that this is Stone's story and that her experience is central. We feel her physical sensations, we connect with her emotions, and we feel the subjective sense of being lost in space. We grasp the physical and emotional C&E relationships through the images.

In this example, a disastrous crash results in a visceral, kinetic, physical experience. **We observe, participate, and emotionally connect.** Our perspective shifts fluidly from a position that feels independent of the character to one that is fully dependent upon and mediated by the character experience. It's like we are brought up and down through levels of meaning, and we emerge with an understanding of what we've seen as a synthesis of all those levels.

This is all without any conscious thought on our part, and without interfering with the ongoing flow of story progress. We can feel the difference between having some stable vantage point outside of Stone's experience and a vantage point that we share with her. That shift from objective to subjective perspective is a huge part of movies. Physical peril is felt in our bodies when we see the whole body of the character tumbling and flying off into the distance. Emotional response is felt through her expression. We simply feel it in the audience. How to make that happen is something filmmakers need to know.

Story information is delivered in a way that orients us to what is important, moment to moment as the story unfolds, and gives us understanding of the objective and subjective character experience. In the chapter on Character Action patterns, I will discuss perspective and proximity in a concrete way that relates to the storytelling.

Dynamism in dialogue

Our next example demonstrates how the seemingly simple patterns associated with dialogue can give us a dynamic sense of story progression through adjustments and modulations. The presentation of dialogue – interaction between characters – is the one filmmaking pattern that most film lovers will easily recognize. Frames with one character speaking (and reacting) are interspersed with similar frames of the other character in the dialogue. That pair of mirror-image framings are so ingrained in all of us who've watched movies for years that we can recognize them without even thinking about it – the Look/See pattern that shows us a single character and their active attention. What they see does not look back. When this is reciprocated, it creates the standard shot-and-reverse dual character sharing of mutual attention. Now we are past the single-character action and into dual-character interaction. Each looks and each sees.

The frames at the end of our first example, from the *Cast Away* dinner, are immediately recognizable because of that pattern of shot pairs. This next example, from *The Incredibles*[4] (Figure 1.5), gives us a rapid-fire group of variations on this basic two-shot pattern of frames that we all understand represents dialogue. This provides shaping of the scene into phases that house the major dramatic beats that signal progression of the story.

This scene opens on the character Helen (Elastigirl) crying. The camera follows her reaching for tissues from the character Edna. We then follow Edna, and we see what's called stacking in depth, where we can connect with Edna's expressions in the foreground while understanding that Helen can't see this – we are in a privileged position of sharing both emotional displays. Edna turns and we get the first pairing of frames OTS of the foreground character. The OTS framing does two things at once. The main function is to connect with the character whose face we see, letting us read their emotions and reactions. But also, by looking over the foreground character's shoulder, we participate with them in this shared context.

Edna does not like the weakness that Helen is showing and comedically seeks to stiffen her spine. She leaps on the table and whacks Helen with rolled up papers. We then observe them both, clearly seeing their relative positions from a side angle. A wide frame from the side shows Edna leaning in, visually pushing Helen to the edge. Then we return to the reciprocal OTS frames in this new position while Edna reminds Helen that she is strong, she is Elastigirl, and she can solve her own problems through action.

Edna moves to the other end of the table and the framing adjusts to sustain her place in the frame. We can feel that Edna is in charge in this whole scene because the camera follows her, not Helen. The character who is followed, or whose movements demand reframing to accommodate their actions, is felt as the center of story agency and dynamics in the moment. **The character who controls the frame tends to have story agency.** This feeling is on the subconscious level for most of the audience. We just feel the energy and it infuses Edna as the character whose actions drive the shifts in framing. Helen, given a literal slap in the face, a good talking-to, and then a little space, rises up and stands tall (spine stiffened!). The scene ends with more concentrated focus on Edna, who relishes the positive results of her coaching.

Two characters talk. We observe from the sidelines at points, but mostly we are totally engaged in the interaction – each character is the subject of the other's attention in a reciprocal Look/See pattern of subjective attention. Dialogue is reciprocal subjective attention, and we recognize that story importance centers on what happens between them. It sounds simple.

If applied mechanically, without regard for the potential of all possible variations, it can be boring and lifeless. When tied to the arc and dramatic "beats" (central moments of story progression), the fluidly flexible dialogue

Figure 1.5



Edna offers sympathy. Next, she reminds Helen that she is a superhero and calls for action. Helen's spine is stiffened, and Edna is pleased with herself.

pattern can be an exciting form of presentation. It informs us that the storytelling is now centered on mutual attention and social interaction. It shapes the scene and orients us to changing contextual cues as it progresses.

The Look/See component brings us into character subjective experience. The mutual Look/See of the dialogue shot-and-reverse pair brings us into the shared subjective experience of social interaction.

In our chapters on Dialogue patterns, we will discuss the variety of ways that Dialogue coverage stems from, and leads back to, the story. We will go further in the chapters on Movement and on Scene Shaping.

Summary

We all love movies and know how to watch them. We have lots of subconscious knowledge that we can bring to our conscious awareness. We can be vicariously engaged in the storyworld and in the lives of the characters. We can even be in their shoes, seeing what they see and feeling what they feel. Cinematic storytelling plays a role in that, carrying weight in the storytelling.

The framing shows us what is important and leaves out what is not. It helps us to experience a range of perspectives on the story. Our understanding is informed and oriented through a shorthand of movie conventions we've all learned.

Our lifetimes of watching movies make the effects of cinematic choice invisible or subconscious. Our job as filmmakers is to become conscious and self-aware of how cinematic choices generate impact and amplify the emotions of the story. This includes becoming aware of how the images clearly present information, and how to align audience experience with character experience.

- Cinematic presentation puts the images in the service of the storytelling, carrying weight in the storytelling.
- The images provide information in context, to help us feel the significance and meaning in actions and performances.
- What is in the frame draws our attention to what is important, and what is out of the picture is no longer significant in that moment.
- Dependence on character perspective creates subjective experience where we are in their shoes and feel what they feel, sometimes even seeing what they see.
- The range of storytelling perspective includes opportunities for physicality and audience mirroring of the character's movements; the comprehension of social interaction information; and access to expressions and the inner state of characters.
- The basic pattern of dialogue – characters talking in reciprocal frames – offers great variability that can shape scenes to show story progress.
- The character who controls the frame has story agency.

Our goal is to make story-centered – not mechanical – decisions about the imagery. We seek to maintain connection to the script and capitalize on cinematic opportunities.

Fundamentals of visual storytelling exist, and we can see them operating through a vast range of different stories and storytelling approaches. The creative freedom is vast. With full awareness of how cinematic storytelling works, any script can have its story tracked and supported. This means that you can put it to use in your own stories, with your own approach and vision.

Common shot list abbreviations

All of the following are in relationship to character framing.

LS – long shot, typically full body. MED or Med – medium shot, typically hips or waist up. MCU – medium close-up, typically upper body. CU – close-up, typically head and shoulders or bust framing. ECU – extreme close-up, typically just face or isolated detail. OTS – over-the-shoulder, referring to using the back of a character's head, neck, and shoulders as a foreground framing device in the shot of another character or action.

What you can do . . .

Watch a scene from any movie you know well. Turn the sound off. Now watch it again and ask:

- Can you follow the general outline of the scene just by following the pictures?
- Was there a moment when something critical happened, and if so, how were the pictures helping to set that up?
- Were you given an observational vantage point at any time that clarified who was there and what they were doing?
- Were you given a vantage point that let you feel like a participant in the scene, looking over the shoulders of characters as it played out?
- Were there any pairs of matched shots that instantly let you know that two characters were engaged in dialogue, whether spoken or non-verbal?
- Did you ever see a character's focused gaze, followed by what you understood to be their POV on the focus of their attention?
- How did any or all of these elements contribute to your sense of what was happening in the story and what it might mean?

Notes

1 *Cast Away*. Directed by Robert Zemeckis, Cinematography by Don Burgess. Twentieth Century Fox, Dreamworks, released 2000. DVD: Twentieth Century Fox Home Entertainment (2001, USA). Start time: 00:14:06.

2 *Midsommar*. Directed by Ari Aster, Cinematography by Pawel Pogorzelski. A24, B-Reel Films, Nordisk Film, Square Peg, released 2019. DVD: A24 Films, LLC, Lions Gate Entertainment (2020, USA). Start time: 00:02:38.
3 *Gravity*. Directed by Alfonso Cuarón, Cinematography by Emmanuel Lubezki. Warner Bros., Esperanto Filmo, released 2013. DVD: Warner Bros Home Entertainment (2017, USA). Start time: 00:12:20.
4 *The Incredibles*. Directed by Brad Bird, Cinematography by Andrew Jimenez, Patrick Lin, Janet Lucroy. Pixar Animation Studios, Walt Disney Pictures, released 2004. DVD: Buena Vista Home Entertainment (2005, USA). Start time: 1:02:58.